Distribution procures and allocates food (principally rice and wheat) to support nutrition through the public distribution system.

Poor Ranking on the Global Hunger Index

The 2020 Global Hunger Index (GHI) ranks India ninety-fourth out of 107 countries. It also classifies countries in categories of low, moderate, serious, alarming and extremely alarming based on their state of nutrition severity. With a score of 27.2, India falls in the serious category.

GHI determines the state of hunger in a country by assessing indicators that measure malnutrition. There are four components: general undernourishment, measured by share of population with insufficient calorific intake; child wasting, measured by lower weight for height for children under five years of age; child stunting, measured by lower height for age for children under five; and child mortality, measured by mortality rate of children dying before completing the age of five.

India has done reasonably well in reducing the child mortality rate; the country's indicator value is only 3.7. Likewise, there is a steady improvement in general undernourishment with malnutrition in the general population going down from 19.8 per cent in 2006 to 14 per cent in 2020. However, malnutrition among children continues to be worrisome. The indicator of wasting in children has gone up from 15.1 per cent in 2012 to 17.3 per cent in 2020. Similarly, the indicator of stunting among children continues to be extremely high (though falling gradually) at 34.7 per cent.

According to the Global Nutrition Report 2018, India is home to 46.6 million stunted children, one-third of the world's total. The 2020 edition of the report, which tracks the state of nutrition based on ten criteria, noted that India's performance deteriorated in six out of ten indicators in 2019, much before the onset of the coronavirus crisis, and that the country did not have data for three of the indicators. India's performance improved only on one indicator.